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Jerry Gordon

Jerry Gordon found an outlet for his musical passion by establishing the Third Street Jazz & Rock Record Store in Philadelphia, and subsequently founding Evidence Records with Howard Rosen. He currently hosts a jazz radio show, "Serenade to a Cuckoo" on WPRB FM.

Jerry was interviewed via Zoom on June 30, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, and Christian Goodwillie, Director of Special Collections.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm going to be joined by Christian Goodwillie who is the Director of Special Collections at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have Jerry Gordon with us today. And I'm going to introduce you as a man who channeled his early obsession for music into a number of very productive projects and is valuable for musicians and listeners. How is that for a mouthful?

JG: Well thank you, Monk, you made me presentable, I really appreciate that.

MR: I think you and I have a number of things in common and one of them would have been staying up late listening to a transistor radio.

JG: Absolutely. And Philadelphia, the station when I was a young teen, 13 years old, was WIBG. And yes, I was listening on the transistor and the story I like to tell everybody about WIBG was it was a station and an era where you could hear the British Invasion, Motown, Dean Martin, and Slim Harpo, all within the same hour and all next to each other on the WIBG Top 100. So that was my start.

MR: I remember the same thing. You know Mitch Miller followed by Elvis Presley. And you didn't have to choose what's my favorite kind of music because it was all there and you could have multiple favorites.

JG: Absolutely.

MR: You said you were "obsessed." I mean I read this in an earlier interview. What do you mean by obsessed at that time? How did it manifest itself?

JG: Well currently I'm on the radio on WPRB. Now I do two hours of a show called "Serenade to a Cuckoo" that is 100 percent jazz. But then I do a third hour. And the third hour is a different show. It's called "Jerry's Room." Okay? And in "Jerry's Room" we play everything but jazz. Okay? And it returns me to my teenage bedroom hiding from my parents, hiding from teachers, hiding from authority, and having all my different electronic equipment going at the same time: my Wollensak tape recorder, my Zenith 200 pound portable record player, my AM/FM shortwave. And this was my young teenage

fortress and where the focus was entirely avoiding homework and listening to music. So the obsession absolutely started when I was 13.

MR: Were you known in junior high and high school as sort of a music nerd? Maybe we didn't have the word "nerd" at the time, but was that sort of your persona?

JG: No. I wouldn't say that was my persona but there were those who laughed at the mention of Moby Grape or Vanilla Fudge. There were those who thought like this kid's out of it. But not a nerd. Maybe crazy. But of course, you know, that was what was happening at the time. It wasn't for everybody but yes, I followed all the trends and I listened to music closely. Loved it.

MR: If you had had a discussion with your parents about 13 or 14, the old "What do you want to do when you grow up?" How would that have gone at that point?

JG: I wouldn't have had much of an answer for them. I didn't know what my future was going to be and in fact my parents hoped, you know, I would become a doctor or a lawyer and all of those things. But they had no clue how to orient themselves to guiding me in that direction. My dad owned a small business, a retail store. My mother did the books. And they did not set me out on this path to be an intellectual or a doctor or a lawyer, they even told me to take Latin and it might help me to become a doctor. But it did the opposite. So eventually I followed exactly in the footsteps of my dad and became a retailer rather than a lawyer, doctor, or scholar.

MR: Didn't he give you a jumpstart on that with a loan saying —

JG: He did. He did. He said, "Jerry, here's X amount of money you can start a business, you can continue with schooling, you must rent an apartment and get the hell out of here." So it was a lump sum "get out of here and you figure it out." It was like that.

MR: I wish that had happened to me. Okay so you're looking at the landscape and you have this passion for multiple kinds of music. What made you think, at age whatever — 20, 21 — that you could be a successful record store owner?

JG: Well let's go back to when I was 13. This is my favorite story. When I was 13 I took the bus from the Philadelphia suburbs to downtown Philadelphia every single Saturday. And I would visit every record store and every five and dime that often sold used 45s, jukebox 45s. I would go to every record store in the city. There was a store here, H.L. Grants had poly wrapped used jukebox 45s. They were all on this big table in no order, just flopped down on the table, a ton of them and I would go through every record. They were three for a dollar. I would go through every record. I would go to every record store and look through every record. And another purpose of my trip downtown every single Saturday was that's where you obtained the WIBG Top 100 list, actually Top 99. And you could get them in record stores and then I would use them to notate which records I had heard

my father was a successful small business owner and happy at it. I grew up with a mother counting the receipts at the end of the day and doing the books. And you know that was the world that I saw. My parents were not doctors and lawyers. They were not intellectuals. And it was really a continuation of, you know, my parents' overview of things. And I had never considered failure. I couldn't afford failure, so I just jumped into it.

MR: Did you get regular customers coming in who eventually would ask you your opinion?

JG: That's what my store was all about. When I opened the store I went to the various one-stops in the city — a one-stop is a place that carried records from all the majors. So instead of having to have an account with Polygram, an account with Warner Brothers, an account with Columbia, and often they didn't want to give you credit as a start-up business, you could go to a one-stop, who carried records from all the companies. And I went to the one-stops, I introduced myself and I said, "Hi, I'm Jerry Gordon and I'm starting a jazz record store." And every one said, "Are you crazy? A jazz record store? You'd better get into some other stuff because that's not going to make it." And there were no other jazz record stores but I was undeterred and that's what I decided to do. And when I opened up the record store I started off with jazz records and sure enough half the people that came in started asking for non-jazz records. Okay? And I saw Jeez — you know one thing I learned from — one of the many things I learned from my father is don't ever let a customer get away. So you know I kept jazz as the center of my concept at the record store but then I started buying R&B and funk you know, and that's how I expanded the store. But I'm proud to say it did not take long before the customers trusted me when they saw I had jazz knowledge and asked me my opinions. I also will mention that I learned so much from my customers, you know I might have been into jazz but I was a white suburban kid and my customers were when I opened up, 75, 80 percent black and they were coming from a whole other place and I thought I knew about jazz and I realized how little I know. My best example of that, I'm sorry I'm really taking liberties with your question, the most requested record, this is to illustrate that point, the most requested record in my store in its history was Little Jimmy Scott "Falling in Love is Wonderful."

MR: I would not have guessed that.

JG: Most requested. And here's a typical conversation. "Hey do you have Jimmy Scott 'Falling in Love is Wonderful?'" "No, sorry it's out of print." "Well could you order it for me? Could you somehow obtain one? Can you copy it for me?" That was the absolute most requested album. I mean other than Stevie Wonder "Songs in the Key of Life" I'm talking about an anomoly okay? And I thought if I ever obtain that record like in a record

I ever obtain this record I'm going to get a fortune for it. I am going to gouge them, I'm going to get a fortune for this record. So I don't know years into my ownership of the record store I got one while obtaining a record collection I couldn't believe it. Did I sell it? No way. Everybody wanted that record. I kept it, okay? I could have gotten all that money. And that is a — one example of how I learned from my customers, even though I knew plenty of stuff my customers knew more and I learned about what people in the black community wanted and that was a revelation to me and I ate it up.

MR: Am I correct that two significant people came into the Third Street Jazz and Rock, one being your future wife and one being Sun Ra?

JG: Yup.

MR: What kind of records would Sun Ra have been looking for?

JG: He would look at — he would go to the Fletcher Henderson section first. And then he would go to the Duke Ellington section. But he never bought anything. He just looked. Christian McBride used to come into my store when he was a kid. Okay? When he was a young kid. He would do the same thing. There's plenty of people that would just go through the stacks and it was a, you know, wanting to see what was happening. I really eventually tried to have every jazz record in print and out of print, cutouts, which were part of my record store. I tried to carry anything that had a shot of selling because to be asked for a record and not have it would be maybe the worst thing that could happen. So yeah, Sun Ra. Danny Thompson would drive Sun Ra down to my store in a big, white Cadillac. Okay? And it was such a trip, you know, to see Sun Ra walk into the store. And it was such a treat for the customers. They would just stand there with their jaws down to the ground, looking at Sun Ra coming in and looking at, you know, at the Fletcher Henderson section.

MR: Was he dressed as we are, as we remember him, in performance garb?

JG: You know Sun Ra never wore jeans. I mean you wouldn't see Sun Ra in jeans. You wouldn't want to see Sun Ra in jeans. He had these platform shoes spray painted silver that he used to wear. And that was always cool. And he didn't have headgear on or anything like that. But it was always Ra-like clothing.

MR: You had said in an earlier interview that Sun Ra was always pushing forward, his whole thing was to turn on the light upstairs with as many people as he could come in contact with. So I'm wondering if he turned on any lights for you? Either at this time or later with Evidence?

JG: He turned lights on before I ever met him. When I was in college I had taken a trip to a college in another city to — and I met someone who played for me the album by Sun Ra "Nothing Is." Okay? And that was my first exposure to Sun Ra, in a dorm room with

my mind. The poetry on the cover, the poetry on the back cover, I mean that — I can't say it resonated with me I would have to say it blew my mind, the music and the whole presentation. And then it just so happens that when I returned to Philadelphia, you know Sun Ra was living there and I would have opportunities to see him. Crazy. And I saw him which remains to this day the — probably the greatest concert of my life. And it still today binds a lot of people, this concert and this scene. There was a place on University of Pennsylvania campus, St. Mary's Church, and they allowed this guy to operate a jazz room — you can't call it a club, there was no alcohol — it was just a space. And it was called Gino's Empty Foxhole after the guy who was putting together the shows, Gino. And after the Ornette Coleman album title "The Empty Foxhole." So he was presenting Sun Ra and I went to see him there and it was the greatest show of my life. The light show was incredible and they had fans on the floor blowing air around the room, not to cool off the people in attendance, but Sun Ra and June Tyson had these cloaks. And when you focused the light show on their cloaks and when the fans on the floor blew their cloaks up into the air, Sun Ra and June Tyson were, there was all these colors swirling on their wings, no longer clothes. On their wings. And they were flying around. They were flying. And when I tell this story to people they say well what substance were you on, you know they do that thing. But Sun Ra knew exactly what he was doing. He somehow, I guess he coordinated it with the people operating the light show, I'm not sure. But it was stunning. And I remember them focusing the light show, it was a tunnel-like spiral focused on John Gilmore, the tenor player. And you could almost see notes flying out of his saxophone into the tunnel. It was that great. Another effect I saw that night was they put like this purple — a purple light. And it was on Sun Ra and his cloak. And somehow I don't even know how he did it, he put the cloak on his head, on his head, really, truthfully, he put it on his head and it gave the appearance that he was sticking his head through a black hole. Because there was Sun Ra without a head. Okay? Just a body. And I wasn't the only one, everybody at this show was in this trance. It was just stunning. So yeah, getting to see Sun Ra in Philadelphia, which you know I had that opportunity many times, that was, that was the greatest.

MR: If someone came into your store and said, "Well I took a chance and I bought a Sun Ra LP and I just don't get it. I don't understand it" —

JG: Every day. Customers would say that about John Coltrane too. Now in my record store we had a record playing every minute that we were open. And my, although I was very much into jazz and its culture, I also needed to make money as well. So I did not play avante garde music while I was trying to do business. I might listen to it at home, I might recommend it, but it wasn't for everybody. So let's say I was playing a Coltrane album

to Coltrane. He played so beautifully and the next thing you know he's playing chicken scratch music. Or he's playing Chinese music." Or something that they could no longer relate to and didn't know what happened to him. Well in Sun Ra's case people would go, "Oh Sun Ra, no. He's out there. He doesn't know what he's doing. He's way out you know. I can't deal with any Sun Ra." And I'd say, "Let me play you one." And then I would play an Impulse album from the 50s where Coltrane, you know, I mean where Sun Ra was playing melodically. Where the music was beautiful. And the people would say, "Wow I didn't know. Wow I didn't know that." And they'd buy it. So as far as Sun Ra goes in most cases it's best to hit them with the earlier music rather than the later music. Or it was for me.

MR: I think you said, "People didn't get his music because they're trying to intellectualize it. It's not an idea, it is just music."

JG: Right. Like with a lot of music people need to go with the flow and enjoy it. It's music. It's not a symbol, it's not — it's jazz and you have to groove with it and not look necessarily for the secrets of the universe before you just enjoy it.

MR: But in Sun Ra's case, do you think he would have appealed to more listeners if his mythology and his clothing and his whole persona — I'm trying to form this question.

JG: If he had toned it down I don't think he would have been more popular. Because he would not be able to do that. This was a total hypothetical. Part of the thrill of going to see Sun Ra was his unpredictability. One time you go there and he leads everybody out into the streets like the Pied Piper and the entire audience followed him, followed behind him. And he took them around the block of the venue and then back and you know, into the venue, and everyone took their seats. It was exhilarating. Another time there was this tall guy wearing like hi-top sneakers. Never saw him before in the Sun Ra band. The guy was about six feet tall, to this day I don't know who he was. But I just remember him wearing hi-tops, having an electric guitar, and when it was time for him to solo it was like he gave Jimi Hendrix a run for the money. There was all that unpredictability about Sun Ra and theater and you know the kind of gentle clapping that is expected at a Keith Jarrett concert, that wouldn't have worked with Sun Ra. He did, he was an entertainer for sure. And that was very important. That was thrilling to his audience. And he couldn't behave any other way anyway.

MR: Did you ever get a sense of what it was like at Sun Ra's home and place of rehearsal? Did any of his members ever describe that to you?

JG: Well I used to go and visit there, Monk. I used to visit the place. This is as thrilling as it gets. When I went to Sun Ra's and the first time I went and he said, "Hello, Jerry." That was it. I had arrived. He knew my name. And he was talking to, I remember very clearly

make a deal with Sun Ra for some kind of video or something. I guess Sun Ra wanted to get off the phone with him and he said, "I'm talking to Jerry. I have to go." That was thrilling to me. So I have wonderful memories of visiting Sun Ra's place and, you know, meeting some of the band there. And there was crazy artwork there, artwork that listeners had sent him or that followers of the band, friends, whatever, had sent him. And the place was what Sun Ra's place you might expect it to look like. It was very cool. John Gilmore lived in the same house as Sun Ra. And John Gilmore was very sweet and soft spoken and no one was, you know from history that no one was more devoted to Sun Ra and his music than John Gilmore, recording very few albums away from the Arkestra. So he was very sweet. He lived there. And there were other members of the Arkestra coming through. I didn't know who lived there and who didn't. I didn't know what was going on. I was just thrilled to be there.

MR: You transitioned to starting a record label and I'm wondering if the change in the music scene caused that to happen somewhat. I read something about the distribution of CDs and so forth. Did it make your — was there a time when your record store became untenable?

JG: It didn't become untenable. What had happened was I started the store in '72 and I sold it in 1989. So that was seventeen years. I put in a lot of hours. I put in a sixteen hour day and I had two children who were, I was really starting to miss out on, you know, their childhood. And the — so that was an issue. Another issue was retailing in Center City was extremely stressful — with all the great things that happened in the community that developed within the store, parents taking their children there and then the children taking their girlfriends there, or people taking their parents there, people knowing each other. There was a really great sense of community in that store. It was great and believe me I still miss that every day. But retailing in a city like Philadelphia, your brain and your body can only take it for so long, or at least that was the case for me. I wanted to see my kids more, I was tired of driving downtown, up and back every day for all those years, driving the Schuylkill Expressway, horrible. And the other thing that happened is Tower Records had opened up. And they now make documentaries about Tower Records and people go, "Oh for Tower Records, what wonderful memories I have at Tower, it was such a hip place." I hated Tower Records. I hated the fact that all of a sudden here was this new place that had way more money than me, advertised way more than me, had fancy plastic bags, yellow and red, and you know, shortly after they opened these bags started coming into my store, you know, and customers — you can't make customers stay loyal to one's — not if you're a record buyer you know. I was never loyal to one record store, why would one? Why would I expect anyone to be loyal to my store? And Tower

sell the business was it was clear that the future was CDs. And my giant inventory would — of albums that I had put together over seventeen years, loaded with cutouts, out of print records, like trying to get my hands on every saleable jazz record there was, was now going to become obsolete. I was going to have to bring in CDs. I was going to have to limit the number of LPs I had. The cost of obtaining CDs was going — and replacing the records I had, was going to cause me to have more money invested in inventory than ever before. So for all these reasons when I had the opportunity to sell my store and it was a good opportunity, I took advantage of it and I sold it.

MR: Okay. Let's move on, it's really fascinating stuff. I want to move on to Evidence Records. And this seems like an obvious question but we often read about the Indies, the small record labels. I don't know if most people including myself know what exactly does that mean? If you're an independent record label owner, what are you independent of?

JG: You were independent of the quote majors unquote. So in my days at Third Street Jazz you had many majors who were, they were RCA, and those who they distributed or other labels that they owned. There was Warner Brothers which included Electra; and Atlantic. There was, you know, Columbia and Epic. So there were like let's say seven majors. Right — there had been a consolidation right before I opened my record store when Electra was an Indy label. Atlantic was an Indy label. Okay? Because they were not a part of these conglomerates. So let's say there were seven conglomerates in the 70s and early 80s okay? I think now there's three. Okay? I mean the record business has continued to consolidate in that way. So while, so at Third Street I remember the first album, the first album on Alligator coming out. I remember the first album on Sunnyside coming out. You know, these are labels that have grown and are revered and they were never owned by operated by or engulfed by one of these larger corporations. Those are the Indies.

MR: So you can say the same thing about Evidence that you weren't having to report up the chain. You were at the top of the chain, you and your partner, and again I'll ask the same question about — I asked about the record store — did you go into this with confidence that it could sustain itself?

JG: I wouldn't have done it if I didn't think so. But opening my store it was okay — what's my rent, what do the records cost, what can you sell them for, how many do I have to sell to meet my rent — okay, here I go, boom. It's like walking off a cliff and you either are, you know you're going to fly or you're going to sink, and I never considered sinking, I couldn't afford it.

MR: Okay. When I look at the list of the LPs or whatever, recordings that were put out on Evidence and I see Nat Adderley and Pharaoh Sanders and Screaming Jay Hawkins and

Sun Ra. It's a very diverse list. What — was there one or two things that had to be happening in the music for it to appear on Evidence Records?

JG: It had to be available and I had to like it. That's the best way I can put it. And I mean the goals of Evidence changed throughout the years. Initially the title Evidence came from I had planned on issuing re-issuing out-of-print records. Remember I told you the customers would say, "Out of print? What kind of out of print? I want it. Where is it?" And so it had become my goal initially, once I had sold my record store, to put out re-issues. So that's how it started and the title Evidence was (a) the title of a Monk tune, and second the records I put out would be evidence of great music from days and years passed. You know evidence of magic from the past.

MR: Okay.

JG: So I started out with two targets. The first one was Sun Ra. That was my first goal. Because I had sold all these hand-made Sun Ra albums at my store that I bought from the band that weren't really distributed anywhere. I used to sell them to Rhino Records when it was a record store in California you know. I was like a Sun Ra sub-distributor which was crazy but they couldn't get their hands on the records. And not only that, as a collector of Sun Ra there were so many Saturns that I couldn't acquire. I just couldn't get them. No one had them, and to me Sun Ra records on El Saturn were like the ten commandments and I only had four or five, you know what I mean? I had to get the rest. And so I knew that putting out Sun Ra records was a divine mission both in presenting this music to people as well — this cosmic music — as well as putting it in the hands of people who had never heard them or didn't know about them or hadn't seen them, hadn't had access to them. So that was my first target. On the other side I had been importing blues records from exporters in Europe, you know, to my store. There were great French and German blues labels as well as jazz labels, but there were some exceptional French and German blues labels. In the — when was that — in the 70s blues was at its low point in the United States. Disco was like it killed the blues. It killed the blues. And there were few people, for example, recording Chicago blues players even. And I was recording, I mean I was importing French recordings of major blues players who didn't have a contract, many of whom would eventually wind up on Alligator Records. So that was my other target other than Sun Ra, these European blues recordings. So that's how Evidence started.

MR: Thank you. Christian do you want to jump in here?

CG: Yeah I'd love to. Thank you, Monk. It's interesting you immediately mentioned those handmade records and your own desire as a collector to acquire the rare El Saturn titles. Because the reason we're even speaking with you is we were lucky enough to acquire the

said that you were about one of the only people in the country that you could get these handmade records from. And I want to ask you, what do you know about the Arkestra's process in creating those covers. Were the musicians doing it? How was that done?

JG: Well I never witnessed it so I can't answer you on that. But I do know that the musicians were doing it. I guarantee you John Gilmore was sitting on the floor with the scissors cutting up stuff. But I can't tell you really the process. I can only tell you that one day they started showing up and then the next fifteen Sun Ras were that way. They were pictures that were hand-colored, or collages that were then laminated on the covers. It was totally crazy. Every one different and that's an interesting thing about Sun Ra, Sun Ra's records. If they had a record it sold out right away, I would ask for some more but it didn't work that way. He did not have a warehouse to keep his records in and an inventory manager. If they ran out of records they would just make a brand new one, a different record.

CG: Well, ensuring the scarcity of so many of them obviously.

JG: So I mean just as wacky as everything else they had done you know. "We don't have that one anymore." Danny Thompson, by the way, was kind of like the head salesman for Sun Ra's record label. He was also the baritone player and kind of the point man for a lot of things with the band. Very nice guy. He died about two years ago now. And he — people started calling him Danny "Ray" Thompson. Originally it was just Danny Thompson, then he was like Danny Ray, and now he's always referred to as Danny Ray Thompson. But anyway, yeah, that's what happened, they would just come up with new ones.

CG: So were the records being delivered in handmade sleeves, was there a standard actual sleeve for these titles or they were only issued in handmade sleeves?

JG: Only issued in handmade sleeves.

CG: Oh wow. Did those command a premium immediately in your store or were they the same price as an Impulse Sun Ra record?

JG: No I sold them for 4-49.

CG: Wow.

MR: That's four dollars and forty-nine cents, not four hundred and forty-nine.

JG: Now they go for four hundred and forty-nine dollars. You're right, Monk. No they went for a regular price.

CG: Wow. Did Danny Ray Thompson, he also ran that Pharaoh's Den store, right?

JG: Yeah. In Germantown. It was like a grocery store. I don't even know.

CG: Okay. You never went in there?

JG: No I never went in there.

CG: Okay. So you started re-issuing these Sun Ra records while Sun Ra was still alive.

JG: Of course. By the way as far as Danny Thompson goes I'd like to tell one more anecdote. When he would bring records into the store, sometimes, you know, Sun Ra would come along with him you know, in the Cadillac. And that's why Sun Ra, you know, came into the store, and let's go down to Third Street, and Sun Ra would look around and then Danny would have a private session with me. There was no standard price. Every load of records was his own negotiation. I had to do it over and over again every time I saw them. It was exhausting sometimes. Danny would say, "Jerry we've got something special here, I'm going to have to charge you more." "What? What do you mean you're going to have to charge me more?" He says, "Yeah, this is special. You should only sell these to certain customers. Not everybody can handle it and we've got to charge more." This is the — every time he brought in records we went through this kind of stuff. But it was fun, it was endearing, it was absolutely endearing and people negotiating with me generally has never been endearing, okay, but in this case it was.

CG: I've got to ask you, Sun Ra is well known for having had certain moral standards and standards of behavior and not liking drugs and alcohol, things like that. And I can think of one Sun Ra record where there's a very prominent profanity in the song "Nuclear War."

JG: Right.

CG: Was that one that possibly Danny Ray Thompson was talking about? Because you didn't hear that word the M-F word on commercial recordings too much in the early 80s.

JG: Yeah, well you know all things change in time you know. That was a different band than — you know these guys like a lot of them had passed away and the band turned over, and things changed. So you know that record really was keeping up with current trends. Okay? It's not like Sun Ra was a I don't know a pilgrim or some kind of you know, got offended by things so I would say that it was really just part of keeping up with the times, Christian. Yeah.

MR: Did you find yourself eventually helping to produce new recordings? Was that part of your goal with Evidence Records?

JG: It was never my goal. I'll tell you why that happened. Good question, Monk. I had made great deals in France and Germany and eventually Japan. I had great deals with King Records and other Japanese labels. I got Toshiko Akiyoshi recordings that way that were not out here. So I was happy doing all that. And then I put out one guy who was particularly and just so the listeners know, I wasn't really licensing French and German and Japanese artists, these were all recordings by American artists that had been made by foreign companies. Now I wasn't the first to license these, there were plenty of labels who were licensing from countries outside the United States, but I really went at it. I

guitarist named Melvin Taylor, and I am going to answer your question. I'm going to answer it through a discussion of Melvin Taylor. Melvin Taylor was from Chicago and he used to play in a club that's still active and very hip and that's called Rosa's Lounge. He did not go on tours of the United States. He didn't really play at other clubs in Chicago. He didn't come into New York. He didn't do that. He had a once a week gig at Rosa's Lounge, this guitarist Melvin Taylor. And he was extremely popular there because he was a bluesy, electric guitarist, not rock he was playing blues but it was rock influenced. And I had to issue — and the only time that Melvin Taylor would leave Chicago and play elsewhere is every summer. The owners of the French, two French labels that I had licensed from, these blues records, they were also promoters. A lot of the labels in Europe were owned and started by promoters who had brought in American artists to tour Europe. And while they were there they would bring them into the studio one day, record them you know, and that was it. And that's why so many European labels were owned by, you know, tour promoters. So Melvin Taylor is in Chicago every week except during the summer, they put him on tour of Europe. They took care of everything, everything was organized for Melvin. And he did that and he had become very very very popular in France. So I had these Melvin Taylor CDs that I had put out in the United States for the first time, but yeah, they were re-issues. They were licenses from these French labels. And the reviews — I actively tried to promote these records and get reviews in the press. And Melvin was getting all these great reviews. People were really loving him. He was like a black Stevie Ray Vaughan. And the reviews, one day I'm reading the reviews — we had a clipping service or the publications would send us reviews. And one day I'm reading this review. "This guy is really great. When is a big label going to sign this guy already?" And I read that and I went oh my God — that second. It was instantaneous. Someone's going to sign this guy, it really should be me. So that's what happened. The very first record that was a new recording for Evidence was Melvin Taylor and the Slack Band. And that was one of the biggest records I ever had, bigger than most of my jazz records, huge. It was a big record.

MR: Did you feel inclined to have musical input, the fact that you were sort of footing the bill?

JG: Absolutely. Doesn't everybody with money who starts a record label? They all want to have input. You know because the labels are extensions of themselves. And so many Indy record label owners — money was certainly not their primary concern, it was to develop a label of taste, a label of hipness you know, a label of coolness. So sure I wanted to have input.

CG: If I can ask a follow-up, as a guy who was in high school and then college working at record stores when your Evidence re-issues of Sun Ra were coming out, it was very very

unobtainable these records were and this was before blogs on the internet or YouTube or anything. So if you couldn't find that record, you couldn't hear it you know.

JG: That's why Hamilton employs you.

CG: So we were scooping these things up, me with my employee discount you know. And I'm wondering as you did the business to be able to re-issue those, were you working with Alton Abraham and Sun Ra or just Sun Ra? I notice they all say Infinity on them, which is their company that goes back to the 50s, right?

JG: Yeah. And the Infinity was just a name. I don't want to get sued for this, I don't think I can, it was just a name I believe. Their business dealings were in the cosmos so it was not incorporated to my knowledge and here's a story I never told before. Here's an exclusive. Very good questioning, Christian. I wanted to do the deal with Sun Ra to license his recordings. And he had asked a promoter, the guy who did Sun Ra's gigs here in the United States, I think his name was Jack Rich if I remember, I'm not positive. I could be totally wrong, but whoever was booking Sun Ra's gigs, and maybe it's not Jack Rich so strike that. Sun Ra chose this guy to represent him. Okay? In negotiations between him and Evidence. And so we had talked and I think we had two meetings. And then one day all of a sudden Sun Ra said, "I can't do this without Alton." And the person representing Sun Ra was shocked and then we were shocked. We had to start the negotiations all over. Okay?

CG: Wow.

JG: And that was done with Alton Abraham and Sun Ra signed the contracts and Alton Abraham did as well. There's an exclusive for you.

CG: That's really fascinating. And I've always wondered, to do those re-issues, did you have access to master tapes or were you doing disc transfers?

JG: You know everything about Sun Ra and Alton Abraham was chaotic. They both died intestate. Okay? You know now all kinds of masters are showing up. I don't know much about that but we had difficulty obtaining good masters. We had signed contracts for certain recordings that I selected. And then we would get a box of tapes from, you know, UPS, and it wasn't necessarily what we had contracted for. And sometimes the masters were not the original masters. Sometimes they were copies of copies. And sometimes the things that we had licensed we didn't get at all. So there were occasions where we went from records. There were. But we didn't mess around. We had one of the finest engineers doing that stuff working for us, Roger Seibel in Phoenix, Arizona. He was like a magician. Sometimes we had to use records to pull out a part and put it in the tape. Everything was rough. They were not always original masters and it was always a surprise, just like Sun Ra.

CG: How did you manage to get the Impulse recordings? Did you work with Creed Taylor in the unreleased Impulse sessions?

JG: No. It's not like that Christian. The — let's see, who was the producer that worked for Impulse and other companies?

CG: Bob Thiele?

JG: Not Bob Thiele. Who produced "Space is the Place"? I'm forgetting his name right now.

CG: I don't know.

JG: Excuse me, I'm going to look it up on the computer unless you want to.

CG: Yeah, I'm actually doing it right now.

JG: All right. Go ahead, please.

CG: Let's see.

JG: Producer of "Space is the Place."

CG: Yes. The album. Blue Thumb, 1973, technical, Ed Michel?

JG: Ed Michel.

CG: Okay.

JG: And he passed away not that long ago, a major, major important factor in jazz, I don't know how often he's been interviewed, I don't really know what's been written about him, but he is one of the heroes of jazz and record labels. He — I'm sure he was the one who encouraged Impulse, a division of ABC at that point, not an Indy anymore, to license Sun Ra recordings and make new Sun Ra recordings. And it wasn't just Sun Ra, very important jazz figure. And by the way, Impulse for a while dallied with quadraphonic recordings, and that was really interesting, where you'd see like these — behind the store, these quadraphonic Sun Ra recordings and you'd go, "What?" I need a quadraphonic record player, you know, to properly, you know, I don't even know if they ever sold a single one or what it was or what the decoding — who knew what that was. I had no idea. But interestingly enough we had gotten from Alton a quadraphonic tape. Here's one of your masters. It's in quadraphonic. And so Roger Seibel had to mix down this quadraphonic, you know, recording to you know a regular recording, you know, coming out of two speakers or whatever. That was a whole trip. But the — I forget Christian, why I went off on this tangent. But yeah, they started doing — Ed Michel helped to institute some kind of program I believe to issue these records on Impulse, and then a masterpiece on Blue Thumb, "Space is the Place" which I think was a quadraphonic recording also.

MR: Well Jerry, we've been at this for like quite a while, how are you feeling about it?

JG: I'm okay. I guess I like to talk about myself I don't know.

MR: That's good. I could see us keep talking on a part two if you'd like. Is there something you would like to add to what we've talked about today? We didn't talk about Pharaoh

CG: And I have a lot more questions my own self.

JG: You're the tough one. Monk is easygoing. You're the tough one.

MR: Well let me suggest that maybe you could do a part two with Christian and continue some of those questions which I know that I couldn't answer so I'd have to leave it up to you.

JG: All right. Well if you guys want to continue fine. There's nothing I'm really dying to say other than explain how I got Pharaoh Sanders on my label. Do you have time for that now or no?

MR: We'd like to hear that, yes.

CG: Yeah I have an hour or so, so I could probably ask my remaining questions, and the Pharaoh Sanders was one of them, if that's all right with you, Monk.

JG: All right. So there used to be a record convention in Philadelphia. The name of the organization was NAIRD — N-A-I-R-D. National Association of Independent Record Distributors, and kind of at the center of that organization was Richmond Brothers which was a one-stop in the Philadelphia area. And so once a year, you know Indy record label owners would come into Philly and they would all come to my store, all of them, and look to see if I was carrying their records. It was really fun to see, you know, they would look, sometimes they would introduce themselves, sometimes they would — and I became friends with a guy, we really got along great and we became friends, and his name was Allen Pittman. And this guy was a very very non-religious, but he was a saint typical of many of the people in jazz as to like making great sacrifices in an unsustainable business in the service of jazz, one of them was Allen Pittman. He was a doctor, not a medical doctor but he worked for the FDA and I think that's the case, I'm not positive. And made good money during the day and flushing it away at night starting a jazz label, which he was motivated to do. And his wife hated it because he was always running around, he bought a van, he signed artists, he started taking all the artists to their gigs, carrying their amplifiers and putting them in his van and doing all this crazy stuff, and the wife could not relate to it. And Allen even, Dr. Pittman, and Pharaoh did a song called Dr. Pitt, P-I-T-T. His wife hated this whole thing and was crazy, and he named the label after her to pacify her, so that he named it Theresa Records. But they got divorced quickly anyway, it didn't take long, but the name stayed. And he was in the Bay area and he started signing his friends. He was an avid concert goer, he was a musician, very very very cool guy. And he had signed Pharaoh, John Hicks, and other — Bobby Hutcherson for one album, other musicians in the Bay area. And he, the records Sun Ra had some people might say, not all people, some people would say Sun Ra's records on Impulse — at the end of his Impulse deal and during the Arista had declined, they were not the great, the "Creator has a Master Plan," "Karma," "Jewels of Thought," you know, some people

Allen Pittman put out, on his Theresa label, two of the great Pharaoh albums ever. Despite that, and he had put out more than two, but there were two two-record sets that he put out that became classics in jazz and for Pharaoh Sanders. And despite that and putting out a series of great albums, he couldn't take it anymore, losing money, getting screwed around by distributors, that kind of stuff. And Allen was a peaceful man. He was not the guy to collect money. "Give me my money or else," that was not Allen Pittman. He was a sweet, soft guy. And then one day I get a call from Allen out of the blue and I only knew him from visiting the store during the NAIRD convention and he said, "Jerry I can't take it anymore I want to sell the record label." So he told me this is what I want, I don't want to negotiate it, this is what I want, you know, I'd like to sell you the whole record label and I think he thought that you know I would do his artists justice and his creations justice and all that. So he introduced me to the artists, he invited Pharaoh over to his place to meet me and I got to meet Pharaoh and I did several times. He was a great guy. And I owe Allen Pittman a lot. The Theresa catalog was magnificent, I put out a lot of good records, a lot of John Hicks records also that were great, important John Hicks records. So Christian that's my Pharaoh Sanders story.

CG: No that's great, I mean I completely agree with you on the arc of the recordings there in terms of him kind of coming back into his own a bit at that time.

JG: Yeah, that was the case.

CG: I was going to ask you, I mean you put out so many great blues re-issues and then some fresh recordings. Your Sam Lay record, was that an original recording?

JG: The Sam Lay recording, a producer/musician, a guy who wanted to have his fun recording, making recordings, you know, made the recording and called the record companies to try and sell it, it's not uncommon, it's very common, and so no. I bought that from the producer of the session.

CG: I wondered 'cause we spoke previously about our mutual love for the Butterfield band and you know his outstanding drumming on the first couple of records there.

JG: Yeah, yeah. I mean that was thrilling.

CG: I'm sure. Frank Frost, the harmonica player?

JG: Same producer.

CG: Oh interesting. Same producer, yeah. Okay. Yeah, great connection there to Sun Records.

JG: Yeah, and a great record, an excellent record.

CG: Yeah absolutely. So I had a few more questions relating to Sun Ra and your experience working with him and the Arkestra. Did you ever have much interaction with June Tyson?

JG: No, only to say hello. To me she was like a Goddess. Like a couple times when I was at

kind of Egyptian headwear and like I saw her running around the house and she might have been doing mundane things to help out Sun Ra but she was still a Goddess so no I didn't approach her. You know. No.

CG: Were you aware, I mean you must have been because of your business relationship when Sun Ra initially had a stroke and recovered to some degree and was able to perform a bit more, but were you in contact with him during that period?

JG: Yeah I was. I remember with my business partner we had gone over there and we actually carried Sun Ra up the steps to his second floor.

CG: Wow.

JG: He was in bad shape and he really had to be carried to the second floor where his bedroom was. I'm telling you people were really devoted to him. And I also saw him I think at the Village Vanguard right after his stroke. So yeah, Sun Ra was alive during all of this but it was bad. He couldn't get around. You know how debilitating a stroke can be and it didn't stop him from playing but it really limited his mobility.

CG: Wow. And you mentioned he died intestate and obviously any business details you don't want to go into but what kind of impact did that have for you in terms of remitting royalties or whatever it was?

JG: Well you know there's always an estate. You have to pay your royalties whether a person is alive or dead there's always — you always have to pay someone and that didn't free us from our obligations to pay. But what was sad, well first of all what was sad was that we were at the end of the deal when Alton Abraham had died. And we were negotiating a deal for more, more releases. You know I was trying to do another ten Sun Ra records and negotiating that with Alton Abraham and then he died and that ended — that really ended my opportunity to continue to work with Sun Ra's music because there was a lot of chaos after Sun Ra died, Alton died, you know, who did you negotiate with now, where are the masters, who is in charge, a lot of people said, "Oh he's dead here's an opportunity." There was a lot of people wanting to buy the catalog, license the catalog, control the catalog, control their estates for others, and because of the intestate situation that was my cue to finally say good-bye to that whole thing. I didn't want — you know there's a word in Yiddish — tsuris — and that word means heartaches and you know the stuff that you know burns out your — gives you ulcers. I didn't want the tsuris of being involved in this free-for-all of Sun Ra's masters and stuff.

CG: I can certainly under —

JG: So that ended everything.

CG: Yeah I can certainly understand, especially given the very congenial and warm personal dealings you'd had with them it sounds like, to go into that feeding frenzy would have

JG: Yeah, we had a warm, I had a warm relationship with Alton Abraham. He was a really great guy. He is — was — the real, the real mystery figure. There was little mention of him and he was a very nice guy.

CG: Did he, did he, I know he moved, well he must have moved from Chicago. Did he relocate in Sun Ra's wake as Sun Ra moved around?

JG: No.

CG: Okay.

JG: Stayed in Chicago.

CG: Oh so he was still in Chicago.

JG: Yep.

CG: Okay that was my misunderstanding.

JG: The first, I remember he flew into Philly and had like a leather satchel, like kind of beat up, and he had masters in there and he flew into Philly and he came to our office and he just gave us the satchel and left the satchel there. And I never got rid of it it was just like another holy Sun Ra artifact, this beat up satchel that he brought the masters in and he just left it there, you know, "Here."

CG: That's awesome.

JG: That was great.

CG: I only have two more questions Monk, and then once we finish the recording I have a couple of quick things I want to ask before we go. But my one last question, we touched on it a little bit but I study intentional communities and there's no doubt that Sun Ra had an intentional community. Did you ever have any sense more about the living arrangements there? I mean did he receive all of the salaries and dole out the money? How did the grocery shopping work? Buying clothes? Any ideas about these things?

JG: Not really but he trusted Danny Thompson a lot and I figure they operated a lot on a cash basis and when they had money, you know Sun Ra gave money to the appropriate party. That's how I figure it went.

CG: Okay.

JG: But I don't know more than that. You know. I don't know if he took out for Social Security or not. I don't know how their money worked.

CG: Right, interesting.

JG: He was on — he had his own thing going on, Sun Ra, interplanetary harmony.

CG: Well I've got to say as a preface to my last question I want to thank Monk for allowing me to be a special guest in one of his interviews 'cause he's a true pro, and he might hate me for asking this question but any Desert Island discs, Jerry? From either ones you put out or just in your life?

JG: I love that question because I have over a hundred desert island discs. But I like to talk about that all the time on my radio show.

CG: Oh of course, yeah.

JG: I like to talk about it and say, announce, "Okay here's one of my desert island discs." The first two jazz albums I bought — I would like to tell this story. I used to shop at Sam Goody's in Center City, Philadelphia. And every week they would take out a column, kind of a big column, I'd say a third of a page top to bottom with a weekly ad in the Philadelphia Inquirer, the number one newspaper. And they would have different labels on sale every week. Okay? Oh my God all Warner Brothers is on sale, you know, and it would be cheap. And this is in my younger days now, teenager, and I was still buying mono records. And with the Sam Goody ad you could buy, Christian, like the new Grateful Dead album, the first, for $1.99 in mono. You know. I mean that's where it was at. We didn't even have a stereo at my house. So one day, and I did this every Saturday. One day I'm looking at the ad in the Inquirer, "Mono Records — we're clearing out all our mono records. One dollar." Oh my God okay, like I flew down there, dollar records. There was a salesman, I'm sorry I'm so verbose on this, on all my answers, but there is a salesman at Sam Goody's he was a hippie. He was the only hippie I knew. He was the first hippie I ever had any contact with and spoke to or spoke to me. And he wore this weird suit, the same one every week, every Saturday, had big lapels. He would have this like wild flower tie, you know, and we would talk music. "Hey how's the new Frank Zappa album?" You know? "How's the new, you know, Grateful Dead album?" So he was my inside guy to music. So I get there for the mono sale, I say, "Oh my God where is everything? Where's the stuff? What should I get?" He said, "Gee Jerry, you're really kind of late, I mean people came in like locusts and cleaned us out of all the rock records for a dollar, are you kidding?" We got cleaned out. I guess the sale had gone on for a week, or whatever it was, a couple of days. So I say oh I can't believe it. He said, "Are you into jazz?" I said, "Jazz, I don't listen to jazz, what's jazz?" And he said, "No, man, jazz is really cool." That is verbatim. And I said, "What? All right, I'll listen to you." So we walk over to the jazz section and he hands me two albums in mono, a dollar each. Guess what one of them was? What is the number one desert island disc for anyone regardless of their age, in jazz? Monk knows. Christian you should know too.

CG: I have a guess, I'll let Monk go first.

MR: I would guess "Kind of Blue."

CG: That's what I was going to guess too.

JG: All right well you guys are winners.

CG: All right.

JG: That was one of them okay. He handed me that in mono, and the other one you won't guess but it's an album that rearranged my DNA for the rest of my life and it remains rearranged to this point, and that was Chico Hamilton "Man from Two Worlds" on Impulse, musical director Charles Lloyd.

CG: Ah. I was going to guess Charles Lloyd as the second one so I was close.

JG: Yup. The musical director Charles Lloyd. It had "Forest Flower" on it, it had guitarist, excuse me Gabor Szabo who played psychedelically you know, he had been a Hungarian freedom fighter when the Russians came into Hungary and then he split. So there is an Eastern influence on his guitar, the music was great. So that was it. Those two records, they are what, those are two desert island discs and they set me off into my career in jazz.

CG: That's awesome. I'm going to check out that Chico Hamilton. The reason I was going to guess Charles Lloyd is —

JG: Yeah I can't figure that, why you did.

CG: Well only because the covers of some of those records like "At the Love In" I think and you know, they've got this psychedelic rock style covers so I would think it would be enticing if you were coming from Vanilla Fudge or, you know, Iron Butterfly or something.

JG: Absolutely. But those were not the great Charles Lloyd albums. I liked Charles Lloyd with Chico Hamilton. There is a series of great Chico Hamilton records. I liked Charles Lloyd "Live at Monterey" that was another classic on Atlantic with Keith Jarrett on piano, a young Keith Jarrett. So yeah, those psychedelic ones were cool looking but the great, to me, the great Charles Lloyd albums preceded those, plus his records on Columbia.

CG: Good tip.

JG: Yup. But you need them, Christian.

CG: Well thank God I have a Spotify subscription 'cause like you I see the dollar sale ad and I'm a beeline to the record store, so I rarely have spare money.

JG: Yeah well you won't be disappointed with "Man from Two Worlds."

MR: So Jerry I'm going to play, to wrap up, you might remember the blindfold tests that they used to run in DownBeat.

JG: I sure do.

MR: Yeah well I have one for you, it's very brief. I don't know if it would make your desert list, but see if you remember this. Are you ready?

JG: If it's an Evidence CD then I don't remember.

MR: Okay.

JG: It's going to be a bad way to end this interview. Go ahead. I won't ruin your surprise.

Oh my God, one of my favorite solos ever. That was my first record. I think that's really why I got into jazz, honestly. We had a 78 player, that was Tex Williams, "Smoke Smoke Smoke that Cigarette." And maybe I was three years old. I had a little child's like baby-like chair that was a hand-me-down from my sister. And we had a 78 player and my parents would sit me down in front of the 78 player, thank you for playing that, and they would play "Smoke Smoke Smoke that Cigarette." And it had that swing violin solo in the middle of it. And my parents, who were not particularly musical people, they were just like hard-working people and they did not sit and play records, although they owned some. They would sit me down and I would listen to that, and they would sing it and they would laugh, they all thought the lyrics to that song were the absolute greatest thing ever. And tell St. Peter at the Golden Gate that's not even my background. But we loved it and everybody was singing it. So yeah, that might be it. That preceded "Kind of Blue" and "Man from Two Worlds" in my jazz education. Thank you for that.

MR: Well it's a long way from "Smoke that Cigarette" to Sun Ra so I'm appreciative of your career and for sharing everything you did today, Jerry.

JG: Yeah thank you so much, both of you were great interviewers and it was a lot of fun for me. Thank you very much.

CG: Thank you, both of you.

JG: All right Christian, thanks a lot.

MR: Thank you. So we are out.